tariff arrangements negotiated through multilateral agreements. For instance, private companies often implement IO lending projects, profiting from contracts and partnerships with these institutions (Malik and Stone 2018). They similarly may have a heavy hand in trade deals and tariff negotiations (Kim 2017).

However, the relationship with elite interests can cut both ways. For populists like Donald Trump or Jair Bolsonaro, whose platforms include environmental deregulation, conflicts with environmentally focused IOs may be not only expected but strategic. For such leaders, aligning with business interests that oppose IO agendas—such as those advocating for fossil fuel expansion—can further their political goals while undermining the IOs' authority.

Populists' opposition to IOs is not merely performative. Instead, it often stems from deeply held beliefs. Many populist leaders are ideologically predisposed to distrust elite-driven institutions, viewing them as threats to national sovereignty and the will of the people. These beliefs may be shaped by personal backgrounds, political experiences, or broader worldviews, consistent with biographical approaches in international relations (Krcmaric, Nelson, and Roberts 2020).

For instance, a populist leader with a history of nationalist advocacy may harbor genuine disdain for the constraints imposed by IOs, such as trade rules or human-rights norms. These ideological convictions can make their opposition to IOs more resolute, driving them to resist both public cooperation and private engagement.

When deciding whether and how to oppose IOs, populists weigh the costs and benefits of their policy choices through a multifaceted lens. If populists view anti-IO rhetoric primarily as a tool to energize their base, they are likely to stage high-profile confrontations with IOs. This may involve public denunciations or symbolic acts of defiance, paired with quiet cooperation behind closed doors to avoid sacrificing the tangible benefits of IO membership. For ideologically driven populists, opposition runs deeper. These leaders resist IOs both publicly and privately, even at the expense of losing access to IO resources. Their resistance is less about strategic calculation and more about aligning their actions with their convictions.

In both cases, cooperation with IOs occurs only when the perceived benefits, whether material, political, or ideological, outweigh the costs. For